How Bogs Keep Bodies Safe for Thousands of Years

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In August 1984, **peat** cutters near Wilmslow in England found a body in a **peat** bog. Known as the Lindow Man, he had lain there nearly 2,000 years, yet was still recognizable. He is one of at least 2,000 bog bodies found in Europe's peatlands.

A **peat** bog is a wet place made of **peat**, ground formed from partly decayed plants. Most **peat** is **sphagnum** moss, which stores water.

The wet moss leaves little air. Bogs get almost all their water from rain and snow, so they are low in minerals and the water barely moves. Without oxygen, the bog becomes **acidic**, and bacteria and fungi that break down dead material cannot thrive.

Instead, the acid pickles a body, like brine stopping harmful bacteria. **Sphagnum** moss also releases **sphagnan**, which protects skin and tissue, turning skin leathery and dark brown. Skin, hair, nails, and organs can stay intact for thousands of years.

Bones are different: acid takes **calcium** from them, so they can soften, bend, or dissolve. Raised bogs preserve bodies best, because they are highly **acidic** and oxygen-free.

Word Treasure

peat -- Peat is soft, dark ground made from plants that have only partly rotted away in wet places.

sphagnum -- Sphagnum is a kind of moss that soaks up and holds a lot of water.

sphagnan -- Sphagnan is a substance released by sphagnum moss that helps protect skin and tissue.

acidic -- Acidic means something is sour and sharp like vinegar, and it can slowly wear other materials away.

calcium -- Calcium is a mineral that makes bones hard and strong.

Background you need

A peat bog is a very wet place where dead plants pile up slowly and turn into a soft, dark material called peat.

Because bog water barely moves and has almost no air in it, the tiny living things that normally break down dead material cannot thrive there.

That is why a body in a bog can stay preserved instead of rotting away, with skin, hair, and organs lasting far longer than they would anywhere else.

Break it down

WHO: Peat cutters near Wilmslow in England, and the Lindow Man whose body they found.
WHAT: A body that had lain in a peat bog for nearly 2,000 years yet was still recognizable.
WHERE: In a peat bog near Wilmslow in England, one of Europe's peatlands.
WHY: Because bogs are wet, acidic, and almost free of oxygen, so bodies there are pickled and preserved instead of rotting away.

Why it matters

Learning how bogs preserve bodies helps you understand why some things from long ago survive while most things rot away.

Test what you remember

1. Where was the Lindow Man found?

- (A) In a peat bog near Wilmslow in England
- (B) In a lake in New Mexico
- (C) At MIT in Boston
- (D) In a forest in Greece

2. What is peat made from?

- (A) Dried animal bones
- (B) Melted snow and ice
- (C) Partly decayed plants
- (D) Crushed rock and sand

3. What kind of moss makes up most peat?

- (A) Sea moss
- (B) Forest moss
- (C) Garden moss
- (D) Sphagnum moss

4. Why can bacteria and fungi not thrive in a bog?

- (A) Without oxygen, the bog becomes acidic
- (B) The bog has too much sunlight
- (C) The bog is full of salt water
- (D) The bog is too hot

5. What does sphagnan do?

- (A) It dries out the bog
- (B) It protects skin and tissue
- (C) It turns water into ice
- (D) It makes bones harder

6. Why are bones different from skin in a bog?

- (A) Bones soak up too much water and float away
- (B) Acid takes calcium from bones, so they can soften, bend, or dissolve
- (C) Bones are eaten by sphagnum moss
- (D) Bones turn into peat faster than skin

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: D 4: A 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):